CA/Browser Forum Tracker

Part 6 - Governance, Network Security and Standards

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About This Report

This is an experimental, AI-driven research project from SRL. SRL is independent, with no outside funding and no sponsors. This tracker is a summarized pull of the public record, kept as a coherent, concise news update. It draws on the CA/Browser Forum's own ballots, mailing lists and published documents, and on the public sources of the browser root programs. An AI model reads those sources and writes the summary, and every statement links to the source it came from. Where two sources disagree, both are reported. AI makes mistakes, so check the linked source before relying on any statement. The tracker is updated each week that the public record shows a change.

This part covers the Forum's machinery rather than its certificate rules. The September edition listed these areas as configured but not yet researched, and they now carry enough record to report.

Section 1 covers the Network Security Working Group, whose one adopted ballot is in review and whose requirements drew two self-reports and a security incident nearby. Section 2 covers how the Forum governs itself, including the officers who take over on 1 December, a vice chair changing employer and a new member. Section 3 covers the IETF standards the guidelines cite, where no post-quantum draft has yet received an RFC number. Section 4 covers the audit regimes that check whether certificate authorities follow the rules.

1. Network Security Working Group

This group writes the Network and Certificate System Security Requirements, which govern how a certificate authority protects the systems that issue certificates rather than the certificates themselves.

Recent Developments

The group's restructuring ballot has passed after a long silence. NS-010 version 2 restructures the requirements sections, removes expired effective dates and updates a NIST reference [1]. Its vote ran from 10 August to 17 August 2026 [2]. No result followed, and on 9 September a participant asked on the list whether the chairs had forgotten to announce one [2].

The result was posted on 14 October [1]. The ballot passed with all sixteen voting certificate issuers and all three voting certificate consumers in favour, and no abstentions [1]. The consumers were Apple, Microsoft and Mozilla [1].

The ballot's text settles a question that earlier accounts left open. One account described an August ballot adding a section on infrastructure inventory, which seemed not to match NS-010's stated purpose. The draft shows they are the same ballot. NS-010 adds a new Section 1 for the certificate authority's infrastructure inventory and renumbers the sections after it [3].

The draft also replaces phased vulnerability management language, which expired on 15 April 2026, with a single requirement covering all certificate systems, support systems and network boundary controls [3]. Its NIST reference moves to Revision 4 of SP 800-63B [3].

The requirements were tested in public on 23 October, when Sectigo filed two reports against itself under the current version [4]. One says an account review was not completed within three months, as Section 2.2.1.4 requires, and the other says an account was not removed from a retired VPN, as Section 3.2.3 requires [4]. Both were unconfirmed as of 25 October and were not re-read this week [4].

A different kind of event touched the same subject on 29 October. TWCA reported unauthorized access to a server of its registration authority, which handles identity checks for certificate requests [5]. The server was isolated, and TWCA says no mis-issuance has been identified to date [6]. Its report cites the Mozilla root store policy rather than these requirements, and promises a full incident report [6].

Current State

NS-010 version 2 is adopted and in its intellectual property review, which runs from 14 October to 13 November 2026 at 18:00 UTC [7]. It cannot publish as a new version before that review ends. The group’s list has had no post since 14 October, and no notice of an exclusion has appeared [8]. Its pull request in the group’s repository remains open and unmerged [9].

The published requirements are still version 2.0.5, from Ballot NS-008 in July 2025 [10]. The group’s other draft, NS-009, would permit log storage systems in environments controlled by third parties [11]. It has not changed since May 2026 and has no ballot stage [11].

Unresolved Conflicts

The Forum’s own ballots page and the group’s ballots page still list NS-010 version 2 as in its voting period [12] [13]. The list posts show the vote closed in August and the result came in October [1]. The list is the record here, and the pages lag it. An update to the pages, or the ballot’s publication in November, would close the gap.

2. Forum Governance

The Forum runs on bylaws, an intellectual property policy and elected officers, and changes to any of them move by Forum-level ballot or election rather than by working group.

Recent Developments

The Forum has chosen a new set of officers in two rounds. A special election for chairs ran from 14 September to 21 September and drew 21 ballots, with results posted on 23 September [14]. Dimitris Zacharopoulos was elected Forum chair, and three working group chairs were unopposed [14].

The network security chair race was tied between David Kluge and Aaron Poulsen [14]. On 24 September it was reported that the two candidates had agreed that Aaron Poulsen would take the chair [14].

The vice-chairs followed. Because no race was contested, the vice-chair ballot ran as a confirmation, from 6 October to 13 October, with no discussion period [15]. Nineteen ballots were received, and the results were posted on 15 October [15].

The confirmed vice-chairs are Karolina Ruszczynska of Certum for the Forum, and Tobias Josefowitz of Opera for the server certificate group [15]. Scott Rea of eMudhra takes S/MIME, Dean Coclin of DigiCert code signing, David Kluge of Google network security, and Ben Wilson of Mozilla the definitions group [15].

A corrected slate of chairs was posted the same day [15]. Stephen Davidson of DigiCert takes the server certificate group and Rebecca Kelley of DigiCert the S/MIME group [15]. Martijn Katerbarg of Sectigo takes code signing, Aaron Poulsen of SSL.com network security, and Polina Glazyrina of Sectigo the definitions group [15].

One officer is changing employer before the handover. On 26 October Tim Callan announced that he departs Sectigo for Microsoft PKI Services on 1 November [16]. He remains a Forum vice chair, because Microsoft is also a member. Dean Coclin, replying as Forum chair, said he can serve until the term ends on 30 November [16]. Martijn Katerbarg takes over Callan’s role at Sectigo [16].

The minutes of the September face-to-face meeting, published on 23 October, record a new member. Huawei’s application to join as a certificate consumer was approved with no objections [17]. An unnamed probationary member satisfied the attendance requirement for voting status, and the Forum agreed to streamline how it reviews candidates, with a chart and standard questions to go on its wiki [17]. A further application, from GeeRoam Information Technology as an interested party, was on the server certificate group’s agenda for 22 October, and no outcome is posted [18] [19].

A proposal for a new working group is also under discussion. A charter for a client authentication working group was discussed on the public list from 22 September to 24 September, with emerging consensus to proceed [20]. Its scope was clarified as mutual TLS for people, not email [20]. Part 4 covers the root program policy that moves client authentication out of server certificates.

Current State

All the new officers take office on 1 December 2026 [15]. DigiCert will hold two chairs and one vice-chair, and Sectigo two chairs [15]. Google, Mozilla and Opera each hold one vice-chair seat and no chair [15]. One incoming vice-chair, Scott Rea, is the eMudhra representative who announced on 25 October that his company is leaving public website certificates, as Part 4 records [21].

The intellectual property policy in force is version 1.4, effective since 1 June 2026 [22]. Ballot FORUM-037 adopted it, and it is the newest Forum-level ballot to pass [13]. No Forum-level ballot is in any stage now, and the Forum’s repository has no commit since April [13] [23]. The client authentication charter has had no post since 24 September [20].

Parts of the record are missing. The server certificate group’s face-to-face minutes are published, but the Forum plenary minutes from the same meeting and from the 8 October plenary are not

[24] [17]. Huawei does not yet appear on the Forum’s membership page [25]. An agenda post of 21 October lists an item on election status and results, but its body cannot be read, so this part rests on the September and October list posts [26].

One public question has drawn no answer. On 29 September a participant asked what “promptly” means in the subscriber obligations of the Baseline Requirements, given that the same document sets hard deadlines elsewhere [27]. No reply was visible by 25 October [27].

Unresolved Conflicts

The notices for recent ballots disagree on which policy version governs them. The review notice for CSC-034 cites version 1.3 of the intellectual property policy, while the notices for SMC020 and NS-010 cite version 1.4 [28] [22]. Version 1.4 has been in force since 1 June. A corrected notice or a statement from the chairs would settle it.

3. Referenced Standards

The guidelines cite IETF standards by number, so a draft becoming an RFC changes what a ballot can reference and when a requirement can be written.

Recent Developments

No post-quantum draft the guidelines care about has yet received an RFC number. The composite signature draft defines how ML-DSA is paired with a conventional signature in one X.509 certificate, and the S/MIME group’s composite ballot depends on it, as Part 3 records. It sits in the RFC Editor queue at revision 19, blocked and awaiting final approval since 19 October [29].

Its companion for key encapsulation moved on 28 October. The status of the composite key encapsulation draft, at revision 23, changed to awaiting editor assignment, after IANA acknowledged its registrations on 21 October [30]. The companion drafts for signed messages also sit in the queue, and a draft on signed-data security is in last call to 10 November [31].

The TLS working group’s two drafts that put ML-KEM and ML-DSA directly into the protocol have waited for an editor since 12 October, after a hold whose reason the record does not give [32] [33]. The TLS group adopted a composite draft of its own on 23 October, which brings composite ML-DSA signatures into the handshake [34]. New individual TLS drafts this week cover a post-quantum strict transport policy, an authenticated key exchange with pre-shared keys and an extendable-output key schedule [34].

The certificate request attestation draft is nearing approval. Its 32nd revision goes before the steering group on 5 November, with a yes position from its area director, two no-objection positions, a ready security review and an IANA approval in hand [35].

New LAMPS work arrived in the week. Drafts for FrodoKEM certificates and for FrodoKEM in signed messages appeared on 29 and 30 October, along with composite variants from individual authors [31]. Revisions of the certificate discovery and one-signature drafts also appeared, and a draft updating the timestamp protocol drew a call for adoption [31].

The ACME draft on account-bound domain labels went backward in October. Its area director began evaluation on 11 October and asked for a revised draft on 14 October [36]. That was the position on 25 October, and the draft was not re-read this week [36].

The Merkle Tree Certificates draft, the basis of the separate post-quantum trust path Chrome and Apple are designing, is still at revision 07, posted on 7 October [37]. Chrome requires new cosigner requests in its testing program to follow that revision, and its draft program text of 28 October aligns with it [38] [39].

Current State

The newest published RFCs in these areas date from August 2026. LAMPS has published nothing since RFC 10031, and the newest TLS item is RFC 10024 on hybrid key agreement [31] [34]. RFC 5280, the core certificate profile, has had no erratum reported in 2026, and its newest is from September 2025 [40]. The CAA standards remain RFCs 8657, 8659 and 9495, as of the last check on 4 October [41].

Authorities still cite these standards loosely. In a bug on list expiry, Let’s Encrypt cited RFC 5280 to argue that a next-update field is a point in time, not a validity period [42]. eMudhra found that its practice statement cited RFC 6844 instead of RFC 8659 for handling CAA records [43]. The RFC texts themselves are unchanged.

The newest change to a standard the guidelines cite came before September. RFC 9919 defines a lightweight status protocol profile for high-volume environments and was published in July 2026 [44]. The ACME persistent DNS draft has stayed at revision 02 since 20 September, as of 25 October [45].

4. Audit Regimes

A certificate authority proves compliance through an annual audit against WebTrust or ETSI criteria, and the root programs read those audits before granting or keeping trust.

Recent Developments

Two clusters of audit-related compliance bugs opened in mid-October, and the D-Trust pair moved again this week. On 15 October D-Trust opened two bugs for findings in its 2026 ETSI audit, one on vulnerability management and one on the documentation of backup recovery tests [46]. On 30 October it posted a full report on the first [47].

The report says the auditors found critical vulnerabilities not addressed within the required 48 hours. It traces the fault to a ticketing workflow not updated after a new scanning tool arrived, and to a security coordinator who left on 30 June without full reassignment [47]. The non-compliance window ran from 30 June to 23 October, and one action on the process is due 2 November [47].

On the second finding D-Trust asked for more time. The conformity assessment body is still evaluating test records submitted after the audit, and the next update is promised for 6 November [48].

On 16 October one member of the public filed four bugs about late audit statements [49]. Each says an authority delivered its statement between 108 and 144 days after the period ended, without the required explanation [49]. The authorities named are ITI Brazil, MULTICERT, Consorci AOC and Entrust [49]. CCADB staff asked Mozilla to review MULTICERT's records on 21 October, and none of the four has changed since [50]. Part 4 covers them with the rest of the incident record.

The Baseline Requirements set the yardstick. Audit reports must be public no later than three months after the audit period ends [51].

Current State

The audit standards themselves did not change. ETSI EN 319 411-1 remains at version 1.5.1 from April 2025, with no newer edition [52]. EN 319 401 remains at version 3.2.1 from January 2026, and EN 319 411-2 at version 2.6.1 from June 2025 [53] [54].

On the WebTrust side, the criteria page lists version 2.2.2 as the base criteria for certificate authorities [55]. A search found no new edition this week, though the page itself would not load [56]. The European conformity assessment bodies' council held its annual meeting in Tallinn on 17 September, and its news page shows nothing newer than a conference call on 15 October [57].

No new audit-related incident was filed between 24 and 31 October [50].

Unresolved Conflicts

Two accounts disagree on the current WebTrust network security criteria. One says version 2.0.5 was released on 31 October 2025, effective for periods from 1 November 2025 and based on the Forum's requirements version 2.0.5 [58]. Later reads found version 1.7 still listed as current, effective for periods from April 2024 [59]. The criteria page itself refused a direct read again this week. A successful read of that page would settle it.

The WebTrust applicability matrix, updated on 1 August 2026, lists TLS baseline versions 2.2.5 and 2.10 [60]. Read as Forum version numbers, neither matches the published sequence. It is not clear from the record whether they are the Forum's numbers or WebTrust's own. A direct read of the matrix would settle it.

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